

Post-incident review PIR-2025-062

Customer Portal: intermittent timeouts

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 22 February 2025, Customer Portal experienced intermittent timeouts in production (AU East) for about 18 minutes. A scripted sign-in probe started failing from two regions. Investigation found that the managed message broker in the region had a partial outage.

Impact

Users of Customer Portal saw intermittent timeouts for about 18 minutes. The service owner, Digital Channels, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:00 First signal received.
- 09:35 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:43 Likely cause identified.
- 10:01 Mitigation applied.
- 10:53 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that the managed message broker in the region had a partial outage.

Customer impact was limited because most traffic was served from cache.

The relevant alert had fired repeatedly the previous week and had been muted by the on-call engineer.

The change was made outside the approved maintenance window.

All traffic depended on one component with no standby.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Write and rehearse a runbook for this failure mode.
- Move certificate renewal into the automated rotation pipeline.
- Add a synthetic probe that exercises the affected path every minute.